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IGB 101: Introduction to Igbo Language and Culture

Tone, orthography and the cultural knowledge behind the words

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Igbo, African & Asian Studies | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Igbo is a tonal language and the orthography is only part of the story. This pack covers the sound system, tone marking, the standard orthography, common grammatical patterns, and the cultural concepts that untranslatable words carry - the ground first-year students most often skip.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Mark tone correctly on written Igbo.
- Use the standard orthography accurately.
- Build simple sentences with correct agreement.
- Explain cultural concepts that translation flattens.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sound, spelling and tone

Tone is meaning, not decoration.

- Igbo has high, low and downstep tones; the same letters with different tone give different words.
- Vowel harmony constrains which vowels co-occur in a word.
- Digraphs and the dotted vowels must be typed correctly.
- Nasalisation and syllabic nasals change pronunciation.
- Write tone marks from the beginning; retrofitting them later is harder.
- Use a keyboard or IME that supports dotted characters.

Basic sentence patterns

Learn patterns, not isolated vocabulary.

- Subject-verb-object order with agreement markers.
- Question formation through tone and particles.
- Negation as a marked form, not a simple 'not'.
- Pronoun series differ by grammatical role.
- Verb suffixes carry tense, aspect and emphasis.
- Learn vocabulary inside sentences you can actually say.

> **Speak from week one**
> Reading grammar silently builds recognition, not fluency. Say every example aloud and record yourself.

Culture inside the language

Some words are not translatable; they are concepts.

- Kinship terms encode relationships wider than the English equivalents.
- Greeting sequences carry respect and hierarchy.
- Proverbs function as argument and precedent, not ornament.
- Names carry meaning, circumstance and expectation.
- Market, farm and household vocabulary reveals social organisation.
- Ask a fluent speaker before assuming a one-word English equivalent.

The language: tones carry meaning

Igbo is a tonal language of the Benue-Congo branch of Niger-Congo, spoken by tens of millions of people in south-eastern Nigeria. It has two principal tones, high and low, and tone is lexical: the same consonants and vowels with different tones are different words. "Ákwá" (cry), "àkwà" (bed) and "ákwà" (cloth) differ only in tone and are not interchangeable.

Igbo is also largely isolating in its verb morphology compared with English: verbs do not inflect for person, so "m na-aga" (I am going) and " na-aga" (he or she is going) differ in the pronoun, not the verb. Aspect matters more than tense; the -rV suffix marks completed action, "na-" marks progressive or habitual.

The standard orthography uses dotted vowels (, ,) that are distinct phonemes, not decorative variants. Writing them accurately is a mark of literacy in the language, and omitting them changes words. The letter "n" before a consonant is syllabic in many words, as in "d" and "mbà".

Dialect, standard and the question of which Igbo